Ramachandran (MGR) or Jayalalithaa overnight. "In Tamil Nadu, the concept of social justice also permeated cinema," says Krishnan. "The semiotic manoeuvres MGR negotiated to become a party leader in the DMK, break from it, found the AIADMK and become chief minister were not something others could easily copy."

Vijay's attempt to create a political space for himself, Krishnan suggests, rests on spectacle rather than substance. "There is this misbegotten belief that, without doing any fieldwork, without engaging people at the grassroots and building a party structure bottom up, one can seize power directly by riding on the shine of one's star image," he says. The tragedy in Karur, he adds, reflects the risks inherent in such ambition. "In such ungrounded, power-mongering politics, it is Vijay's fans who get caught in the middle and are degraded."

Milking a Tragedy

Meanwhile, with the assembly election less than a year away, politicians of every hue are making a beeline for Karur. A delegation of NDA MPs from outside the state, led by BJP's Hema Malini, met local officials and victims' families. Later, while calling for an impartial judicial probe, the former actress remarked that there was "something fishy" about the incident. This immediately sparked criticism about the 'targeting' of non-BJP states by the Centre. Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi leader Thol Thirumavalavan, who is part of the ruling DMK alliance, accused the BJP of trying to milk the tragedy to score political brownie points.

The DMK itself has been exercising extreme caution, wary that they would get some of the blowback about the security arrangements. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin went down to Karur to meet the survivors. The state also announced Rs 10 lakh compensation each for the deceased and appointed a one-member judicial commission headed by retired high court justice Aruna Jagadeesan to investigate the incident. According to sources, the commission will examine crowd control measures, safety protocols and possible lapses in event management.

In all this, what lies exposed is the disarray in Vijay's camp. "It's not just about how he was missing in action after the Karur tragedy, the party itself was in chaos," says political analyst Srinivasan. "He has not owned up or taken responsibility as a leader." When Vijay finally emerged and spoke through a video message on September 30, it was to strike a defiant note and hint at conspiracy theories. "Why did this happen in Karur alone?" he asked. "People are watching. Truth will come out soon." He even issued a direct challenge to Stalin. "If you want revenge, take it out on me. Don't touch my comrades.... Do anything to me." According to some observers, the DMK's overcautious approach—in not taking immediate action against the star, fearing a sympathy wave—may have actually backfired. While criminal cases have been filed against lower-ranking members of theTVK and some arrests made, the actor himself has not been named in the FIR.

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Given Vijay's enormous popularity, Tamil Nadu CM Stalin has been wary of implicating him. But his defiant, accusatory statement may force the DMK government to take action

Hardening Stand

The TVK cadre has been floating conspiracy theories linking former minister and DMK Karur strongman Senthil Balaji to the stampede, but the ruling party has rejected these claims. In Srinivasan's view, this confirms the trajectory that Vijay and the TVK will pursue: "He'll continue to oppose the DMK...if anything, Karur may harden his combative stand."

However, after Vijay's video message and insinuations of foul play, the government has gone on the offensive. At a press conference in Chennai, additional chief secretary P. Amudha and other officers gave a minute-by-minute account of how the tragedy unfolded, with videos and images to refute the allegations going around in social media. The officials also explained why the police had allocated Veluchamipuram for the rally after rejecting seven other sites for safety reasons. On Vijay's charge of why in "Karur alone", the government claimed TVK rallies had resulted in one death at the Villupuram event and two in Madurai. There had been many injuries too, the officials said, blaming the organisers for the disasters.

The TVK's troubles may not find sympathy among other parties in Tamil Nadu. For AIADMK, Vijay's rise had been a double-edged sword: he could hurt the DMK but also mop up anti-DMK votes. "They are perhaps secretly happy that Vijay has suffered this setback," says Srinivasan.

For all his belligerence, the Karur tragedy will be a moment of reckoning for Vijay: can he weather this storm? The *Ilayathalapathy*, young general to his fans, might flex muscle in video messages, but this is no three-hour potboiler where the hero endures, rallies and wins. To regain lost ground, Vijay will need less bravado, more introspection. ■